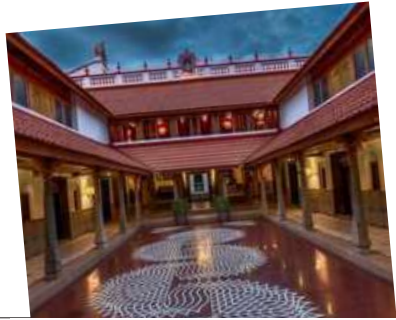




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THE HINDU

Kalai turns Chettinad's mansions and temples into an immersive classroom **P2**

TN 2026: THE LATEST POLITICAL SATIRE IN TOWN **P4**



Meet the irreverent film composer whose self-deprecating humour is driving Tamil cinema's thriving promo culture



Track record
Rajinikanth, Kamal Haasan with Nelson and Anirudh; (below) GV Prakash and Ken Karunas in *Youth* and a still from Sai Abhyankkar's 'Pavazha Malli' track. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

PROMO CODE

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Kamal Haasan and Rajinikanth walk together towards a car, as a catchy track ('Aaja Raja') plays. They get in. In what is a promo for the biggest Tamil project in recent times – one that marks the reunion of two superstars – director Nelson and music composer Anirudh also make a mark. For films like *Doctor*, *Beast* and *Jailer*, this duo has worked on irreverent, self-deprecating humour that has drawn a fan base. While composer Anirudh is the most sought-after for such videos, having also done material with Vignesh Shivan (*Love Insurance Kompany*) and AR Murugadoss (*Madharassi*), many other Tamil music directors are also getting on board this trend. They now also incorporate elements of popular perception about them, keeping the mood light and self-aware. While AR Rahman's *Moonwalk* preview featured him trying to revive a cassette-like experience,



Harris Jayaraj was 'kidnapped' mid-air for a playful promo for *Kadhal Reset Repeat*. Yuwan Shankar Raja went to another extreme for *Jiiva47*, with director Rajesh and actor Jiiva pulling his leg over copyright issues that are famously associated with his father, Ilaiyaraaja. Meet the modern irreverent Tamil music composer, who does not take himself too seriously. "It's fun," admits composer-actor GV Prakash, "It helps the audience check out how the team is, the vibe of the song and the film." His now-viral 'Mutta Kalakki' from recent Tamil flick *Youth* featured a 'singer announcement', where Ken Karunas is featured pleading with Prakash to give him an opportunity to sing, much to the amusement of the others in the team. For the 'Aadiney Irupen' promo in *Happy Raj*, Prakash roped in composer Justin Prabhakaran. "When audiences see such excitement among the cast and crew, they relate to the film and decide to watch it," he adds. **Adding to the hype** 'Hip Hop Tamizha' Adhi was among the



early birds of this trend, when he innocently asked Vishal and Sundar C, '*Intha pallavi charanam na enna*' (What is this pallavi and charanam that you are talking about?) for *Aambala* (2014), heralding a new wave of promo videos, thus shifting the focus from traditional musical grounding to modern pop-cultural instinct. But this is not about promos alone. It also signals a larger trend: of the current-day music composer, who may or may not be rooted in classical music training, but still comes up with a tune that resonates with the soul of the film and connects with the audience. From being a behind-the-scenes personality, he has evolved into an on-screen one – thus driving a promo culture that adds to the hype of a project.

"The modern Tamil composer is no longer just a musician," explains Santhosh Kumar, vice president, Think Music, "He's a performer, a brand, a content creator and sometimes even a face that can sell a film. Look at Anirudh and Sai Abhyankkar... their presence alone generates hype." While other film industries also have popular composers, what sets the Tamil film industry apart is how fans keenly follow the personality of the music director and not just his tunes. "In no other industry does the composer hold this kind of cultural weight. People don't just listen to Tamil film music; they follow the composer. They pick sides. They celebrate albums like events. That emotional investment from the audience is



AR MURUGADOSS,
Director



SANTHOSH KUMAR,
Vice president, Think Music

what makes the promo culture possible here," explains Santhosh.

Emotional investment Such offbeat promos might be a new trend for today's fans, but director AR Murugadoss states that he has seen such material in the past. The *Ghajini* filmmaker

In this social media-age, such promos are an inexpensive, attractive way of reaching out to the younger section of audiences

Promos set the mood before the release. We build anticipation so that by the time the track drops, people are already emotionally invested

remembers listening to a promo for the audio release of *Guna* (1991), featuring Kamal Haasan, Ilaiyaraaja and lyricist Vaalee. "The audio cassette featured an interaction between the three of the concept and birth of the soundtrack," recalls Murugadoss, whose favourite promo was Aamir Khan's video for *Delhi Belly*, in which he uses a cuss word. This prompted Murugadoss to star in a promo himself – he appeared in a zany video for Anirudh's 'Salambala' track in his *Madharassi*, an idea proposed by actor Sivakarthikeyan. "In this social media-age, such promos are an inexpensive, attractive way of reaching out to younger audiences," states Murugadoss, adding that these are better for a production team to release rather than push BTS or scenes from the film itself. This is not limited to film tracks alone. Indie offerings are also conjuring new promos and unplugged versions, in order to ensure reach of the song. "Today, one of the biggest reasons behind the success of our indie tracks is the promos that set the mood before the release," adds Santhosh, referring to the Think Indie series, which recently put out the 'Pavazha Malli' song featuring Sai Abhyankkar, "We understand how to build anticipation so that by the time the track drops, people are already emotionally invested."

The resistance rainbow

Four editions in, Neelam's annual Dalit History Month celebration Vaanam, gets a new lease of life

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For four Aprils now, as Chennai's summer breeze sets in, Prasad Lab has brimmed with film enthusiasts waiting to watch what the PK Rosy Film Festival has to offer. The slate, full of world cinema particularly fitting the resistance genre, has not just made for compelling viewing. It has ensured space for a genuine attempt at furthering intellectual conversation, particularly about political and marginalised

movements. Over the years, this festival, part of Neelam Cultural Centre's Vaanam, a Dalit History Month celebration commemorating BR Ambedkar, has seen cinephiles packing crowds, and even sitting on the floor of cinema halls. This year, for the first time, the film festival opens itself up to four competitive categories. It will be held between April 8 and 12 at Prasad Lab in Saligramam and Goethe Institut. Curator of this festival, Arun Karthick, says that he has witnessed a perceivable paradigm shift as there has been a steady rise in the emergence of



gender sensitive, queer, and highly political cinema. "The memory of injustice in these films is evident. Over the last two editions, the festival has spotlighted some directors surrounding certain themes. This year, we are shining the light on the black filmmakers of America from

the 1970s and 80s," he says, adding that films by Cheryl Dunye, Ava DuVernay, Ken Loach, Julie Dash, and Ryan Coogler, will be part of the screenings. This year, Arun and his team had to sift through 450 films to arrive at the final 28 films in competition. There are eight films in the fiction feature and short fiction feature category, and six each in the short and long documentary format. Films like *Sabar Bonda* (Marathi for 'Cactus Pears'), a film on queer love, which

What liberates you? (Left) From the previous editions of Vaanam; (inset) Pa Ranjith and Ramachandra Guha. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

won the Grand Jury Prize at the 2025 Sundance Film Festival will also be shown. A special showcase of films by Tamil directors will also be part of the mix, an exciting prospect for filmmakers from Chennai. "There are films from all over India, particularly films from the Northeast, that will surely make for great viewing. Exciting times," says director-curator Arun. Taking off on the excitement is editor, Neelam Publications, Vasugi Bhaskar, who curates other parts of the Vaanam festival including Verchol, the annual literary festival (on April 18 and 19), and Dhamma, an immersive attempt at dramaturgy (on April 26). Vasugi Bhaskar is clear that there has been an attempt to look beyond a Dalit person's poverty, and focus instead on Dalit art and aesthetics, thanks to the festival. "A walk into any of the festival's venues will prove that Neelam is inclusive entirely. There is

an attempt to speak of privilege, marginalisation, current affairs, in a thoughtful and political manner," he says. On the inauguration of the Vaanam festival on April 4, Neelam's founder, Tamil director Pa. Ranjith, who has championed the cinema of resistance in this State, spoke of how Dalits have led and played pivotal roles in uplifting people across caste-lines. Vasugi Bhaskar says that the literary festival and the theatre festival will choose to do the same. Speakers from Kerala, Sri Lanka, Telangana, and Maharashtra will be part of the festival and several other prominent Tamil names. Natarajan Gangadharan's work at Vaanam Art Festival will make their way to an exhibition curated by him at The Whole Story between April 12 and 18. "Resistance finds an easy solace in art. We are excited to see what the younger artists have in store for us," he says. **For more details, follow @vaanam_art_festival on Instagram.**



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I expected a holiday. I got a lecture.

We sit cross-legged on the floor, notebooks open, as architect Sashikala Ananth pulls a measuring tape out of her handbag with the delight of a conjurer. She begins to measure a wooden pillar, running through a series of calculations with her audience, the logic behind the compelling visual rhythm of Chettinad’s 200-year-old mansions becomes evident: they are built on precise math.

At a time of doom scrolling, intellectual flattening and 30-second attention spans, Kalai, The Chettinad Art and Architecture festival feels like a quiet pushback. Curated by The Lotus Palace Chettinad, a part of The Park Hotels group, the festival spans four days of information-packed lectures that demand attention.

Chettinad’s stark, arid landscape and maximalist mansions turn into a classroom, where architects, historians, artists and locals teach. Instead of photo ops and drive-by tourism, we attend power point presentations on design in darbar halls lit with stained glass, walk through symmetrical courtyards to understand rainwater harvesting and explore temples carved out of rock to decode iconography.

The region has been drawing tourists, designers, architects and

Instagrammers for its gigantic mansions, each spanning 40,000 sq feet and more, rising seemingly out of nowhere in small dusty towns. But few look beyond the region’s obvious treasures: Athangudi tiles, mansion selfies and fish curry.

This is changing.

Starting with The Bangala’s influential Chettinad festival, which launched in 2022, the focus has been on immersive learning, drawing visitors who are looking for more than just a holiday by the pool.

And if Meenakshi Meyyappan of The Bangala is best known for putting Chettinad on the global map, Priya Paul, chairperson of Apeejay Surrendra Park Hotels, is now amplifying this effort, first with Vaadyar’s House in 2018, followed by The Lotus Palace Chettinad in 2025.

Last year, the Lotus Palace launched Suvai, a food festival highlighting neighbourhood nannari sherbet, pickle and vatthal makers. This year, the focus sharpened with Kalai, held as always, in collaboration with the region’s most prominent hotels: The Bangala, Chidambara Vilas, Visalam, Saratha Vilas and Chettinad Mansion.

Kalai, priced at ₹75,000 per couple drew a compact, but attentive, detail-oriented audience, proving that people are willing to pay for experiences that merge luxury with learning. They listened carefully and asked thoughtful questions after each session.

The festival begins with architect Sujatha Shankar deftly packing 200



School’s in session
(Clockwise from far left) The Lotus Palace in Kanadukathan; architect Sashikala Ananth taking a class on *Vastu Shastra*; architect Sujatha Shankar on the evolution and planning principles of Chettinad architecture; and Sashikala Ananth measuring a wooden pillar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The Chettinad classroom

At the Kalai festival of Art and Architecture, curated by The Lotus Palace, historic mansions become spaces for learning, drawing travellers who are trading passive sightseeing for deeper, more thoughtful engagement



years of Chettinad architecture into one hour, using diagrams to explain how the elaborate balustrades, defined high plinths and colonial arches came together.

Chettinad was shaped by the Nattukottai Chettiars, who travelled the world for trade, and came home to build this majestic architectural landscape between the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Spread across about 75 villages, it had about 15,000 mansions at its peak. Today, fewer than 10,000 remain – many unoccupied.

While I knew that these houses were filled with treasures from around the world, Italian marble floors, Burmese teak pillars, Belgian mirrors and even British steel beams, I did not realise they were also a practical solution to a logical challenge. “The Chettiars sent out

ships filled with spices, cotton and sometimes peacocks. The ships had to come back with a certain amount of weight to stay stable, and that’s why they brought in all the heavy steel, marble and teak,” Sujatha says.

The facade of the 230-year-old Lotus Palace is joyous with fantastical details in stucco: Hindu gods and goddesses, a dapper British man in a bowler hat with a dog and walking stick, and a yali-inspired guardian on an elephant. “It’s an electric amalgamation of all styles,” says Sujatha, as she explains how the interiors, in comparison, follow a distinct layout. “The plan of any mansion has a central spine around which the courtyard and rooms are arranged.”

On day two, Sashikala Ananth resumes class at AR House, introducing the *Vastu Shastra* and explaining how multiple courtyards, which flood the homes with sunlight, are the “backbone of the structure.” She adds, “Measurements are critical. That is what gives visual order. In South India, our music is also based on playing with numbers,” she says, adding with a laugh, “We are number freaks.”

We later gather at the Sathyagiriswarar Temple at Thirumayam Fort to understand the region’s temple architecture. “We are standing in a gouged-out granite rock. Remember this was made in the 7th Century with just a hammer, chisel and plumb line,” says historian and author Pradeep Chakravarthy.

As Kalai winds now, Kathiravan Karunanithi, the manager of Lotus Palace, who grew up in the area, echoes a popular local lament: “The older generation lives here, or visits often. Their children come for every festival and weddings. Their grand children visit once a year. Four generations from now, they will ask, ‘where is Chettinad?’”

This is what festivals like Kalai are trying to shift – drawing people back, and giving them a reason to preserve what remains.

The writer was at Kalai on invitation of The Lotus Palace Chettinad.

Textile treasures

Saris become the focal point of the Crafts Council of India’s textile showcase Tari – The Loom, with weaves from across the country

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At the Crafts Council of India’s annual textile show Tari-The Loom, set to take place in Chennai on April 10 and 11, every sari, and piece of fabric spotlights a story: one that elaborates on craftsmanship, artistry, skill, and even history.

Established in 1964 by social activist and freedom fighter Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, the Crafts Council of India (CCI), a voluntary, not-for-profit NGO has made it their mission over the last 60 years, to preserve and promote India’s many handlooms and handicrafts. At Tari, the spotlight will be on the sari, with weaves that include rare eri silks from Assam, khadi mul, batik, bandhani, and ajrakh. Also a part of the textile show are shawls, stoles, dupattas and fabrics. This year, 31



designers and brands from across the country, including many who have been returning to Chennai for over 15 years to showcase their work, will be participating.

Shripal Shah of Asal, who has been coming to Chennai from Gujarat for the last 12 years says their collection includes fabrics made of yarn handspun on a traditional charkha which runs on a

Saris and stories (Above) Bandhani sari by Sidr Craft; and a jamdani sari by The Far East Art Studio. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



single spindle. “This fabric is ideal for summer, and we have shirts, kurtas and jackets. We are also bringing the brand’s signature non-violent silk saris [Ahimsa silk] and matka silk saris,” he says.

While their lightweight bandhani saris and scarves have always enjoyed a steady reception in Chennai over the last 15 years, Abdul Jabbar Khatri, co-founder, Sidr Craft from Bhuj says that bandhani’s similarity to Tamil Nadu’s sungudi, both made using traditional tie-and-dye techniques, is another aspect that always comes in for appreciation. Pracheen, a handblock printing unit in Mumbai which eschews synthetic dyes and chemicals and uses natural colours from plants, roots and herbs, will showcase craft printing on silk and cotton saris, dupattas and stoles, says Sarfraz Ahmed Khatri, CEO.

For Rajeswari Sengupta and Madhumitha Sengupta, founders of Kolkata-based The Far East Art

Studio, museums across the world provide a fascinating insight into textile traditions and history.

“We work on Dhakai jamdanis and baluchari weaves and over the years, have studied and remade designs from the 19th Century. Out collection at Tari includes a Dhakhai jamdani we have reimaged based on a sari we saw at the Indian Museum in Kolkata. It took two weavers 10 months to weave,” she says.

Other participants include Okkiyo, a Santiniketan-based sustainable fashion initiative showcasing handspun khadi, eri, mulberry and matka with natural dyes; Radha Krishna Handloom from Telangana which specialises in naturally-dyed double ikkat saris; Kalenele, which focusses on the revival of khunn and ilkal weaving techniques and kasuti embroidery from Karnataka, and Gamthiwala which has Maheshwari, linen, mulmul khadi cotton and Chanderi saris.

Tari – The Loom by Crafts Council of India is on April 10 and 11 from 10am to 8pm at WelcomHotel by ITC, Cathedral Road.

A summer showcase



Explore eco-printed khadi, kalamkari saris, and artisanal crafts at Gandhigram’s Summer Pop-Up in Chennai

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Gandhigram, a social organisation promoting sustainable living and rural development, will present its annual exhibition, Magic of Khadi – a two-day summer pop-up. The event will feature a curated showcase of hand-spun textiles, kalamkari fabrics, saris, towels, dhotis, everyday khadi clothing, and village industry products crafted by Gandhigram artisans.

Aditi Jain, textile designer for Gandhigram, says this year’s highlights include eco-printed fabrics, as well as kalamkari and muslin saris, designed by the Centre of Excellence for Khadi (CoEK), New Delhi.

Five eco-printing workshop sessions will be held over the two days, allowing participants aged eight and above. The workshops are priced at ₹750 per person. In this art, plant-based dyes are used along with real leaves, flowers, and plant matter, which are placed

on fabric and then pressed, rolled, or steamed to transfer natural pigments.

“We also have a 72-count Idaikal cotton khadi sari, which gives a soft and comfortable drape. This weave is wrinkle-free, does not require starching, and falls well,” says Aditi.

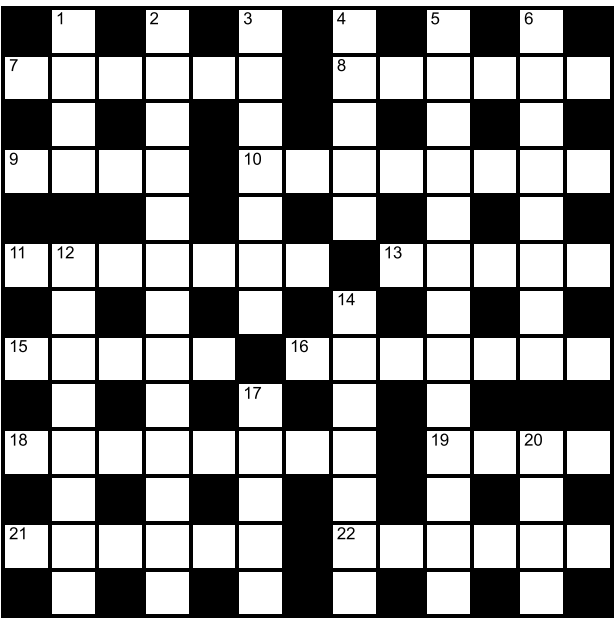
The ready-to-wear category includes kurtas, western tops, shirts, dresses, and jumpsuits for women, and shirts, dhotis, and kurtas for men. Women’s wear is available on sale. Also check out Gandhigram’s eco-printed towels, alongside eco-printed yardages.

The exhibition will feature Gandhigram’s village industry products, crafted by its artisans.

All proceeds from the sale go towards Gandhigram’s developmental initiatives. Established in 1947 under the guidance of Mahatma Gandhi, the Gandhigram Trust aims to build an independent and self-reliant rural India.

@ CP Arts Centre, Teynampet. April 10 and 11, 10am to 8pm. To register for eco-printing, call 9712606705.

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #48 (Set by Doppelganger)

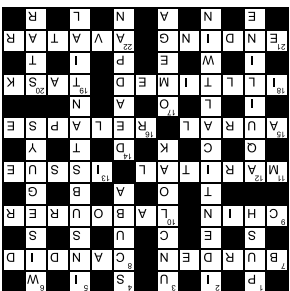


- Across**
- 7 Encumbrance (6)
8 Outspoken (6)
9 Portion of lower jaw (4)
10 Unskilled worker (8)
11 Conjugal (7)
12 Matter of discussion (5)
15 Relating to the ear (5)
16 Backslide (7)
18 Untimely (3-5)
19 Assignment (4)
21 Termination (6)
22 Incarnation (6)
- Down**
- 1 Shove (4)
2 Born from same pregnancy (9,4)
3 Expose (7)
4 Diving equipment (5)
5 Weak (13)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



Solution No. 48



Festive Flavours

This Tamil New Year, Waterside presents Puthandu on a Plate, a festive lunch that brings together traditional Tamil flavours and seasonal specialities. The menu features a mix of regional favourites such as Pallipalayam mutton chukka, nethili karuveppilai varuval, and a main course anchored by the the State’s classic seeraga samba biryani and accompaniments. A selection of traditional desserts including Mysore pak and semiya payasam completes the experience.

@Feathers Hotel, Manapakkam. April 14, lunch only. Priced at ₹2,400 per person. For reservations, call 73050 03390.

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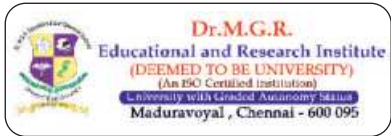
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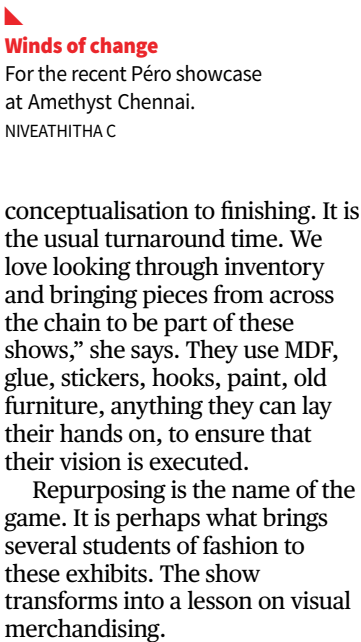
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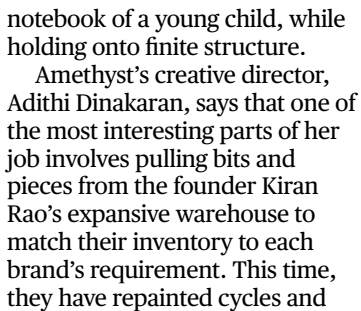


At Amethyst Chennai, founder Kiran Rao has shaped The Folly into a space where designer showcases make fashion interactive. This week, it's a child's canvas with Pero

The Folly at Amethyst Chennai has a particularly distinct quality.

Every time a designer's show takes place at the venue, pop, comes a mannequin draped in resplendent garb, welcoming visitors to walk into an experience. Much like the deceptive scales of a chameleon, the busy event space transforms, reflecting the colours of ateliers who bring their wares to the city from far away lands.

This week until April 9, The Folly brims with bright hula hoops, painted mirrors, a crew of crayons, hand-drawn stickers, and several other knick-knacks, complementing Aneeth Arora's newest collection at Péro titled Doodles. Much like the collection, The Folly transforms into a canvas, resembling the drawing



fans, doodled on gada cloth to make playful lampshades, and brought blue storage cartons from their cafe, to ensure that the space is as bright as the collection.

“The Folly is a busy space so we get little time to set up. This is the only challenge, but it is one that we enjoy taking on as a team. This current collection took us a week to put together from

Working with weavers from Bhavani, Ramraj Cotton has introduced a line of jamakkalams and tote bags, and has launched two books

In the town of Bhavani, three rivers meet and so do colours, threads and stories,” writes Lakshmi V, in the children’s book, *From Bhavani*, *With Love*, published by Karadi Tales.

These stripes of colour across the spectrum, from red and green to purple and yellow are a common sight in Tamil Nadu; as jamakkalam or large, thick carpets on the floors of homes, temples, wedding halls or even at sombre gatherings. Over the last few years, the jamakkalam has gone places; featuring on clothes, bags, rugs and more.

Focussing on newer colour palettes, contemporary patterns and utility formats, ethnic wear brand Ramraj Cotton has now introduced jamakkalam rugs and bags, working with weavers in Bhavani. For KR Nagarajan, the

culturepreneur, founder and chairman, this move beyond apparel is one where the origins feel all too familiar.

“When I began working on veshitis nearly 43 years ago, we ended up working with many weavers to revive looms and bring the garment to the forefront. There are so many things of great cultural significance across the country that do not have enough patronage, and we were keen to work on jamakkalamas with weavers in Bhavani,” he says.

He stresses on what having a platform like his means, that is able to take the product and market it in such a way that the next generation continues to

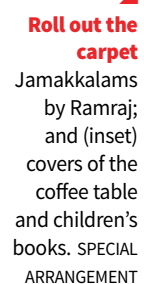
highlight its significance.

In maroon and yellow stripes, or in deep purple with white and teal stripes, the jamakkalam made by Ramraj come somewhere between a small to medium dhurrie size, perfect for smaller apartments. The jamakkalam pattern also lends itself to cotton tote bags, available as a part of this new line of products. While the jamakkalam are priced at ₹1,795, the tote bags are priced at ₹2,045.

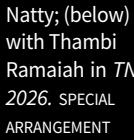
Ramraj has also launched two books on the famous striped carpets. The children's book *From Bhavani, With Love* (in English) and *Anbudan Bhavani* (in Tamil) by Lakshmi V feature illustrations by Zainab Tambawalla and photographs by Amar Ramesh, tracing the story of little Sumi, whose grandfather is a skilled weaver working on jamakkalam.

A coffee table book, *Bhavani Jamakkalam: People's Dhurrie Of India* published by Mara Labs encompasses a sprawling collection of photographs and the documentation of Bhavani and its resident weavers who breathe life into the jamakkalam by Amar Ramesh.

The jamakkalam rugs and totes are available for sale on ramrajcotton.in. The books can be purchased at select Ramraj Cotton outlets, or from karaditales.com and at maralabs.in



How a stoic Natty and a lively Thambi Ramaiah came together for political satire *TN 2026*



Actor-cinematographer Natty seems calm and composed ahead of the interview, as he chats about paintings, cinematography and the difficult process of a film's post-production. "Many underestimate the difficulty and importance of sound mixing," he says, and shortly later, actor Thambi Ramaiah makes a loud entrance. The air in the room shifts instantly. On one hand, there's Natty, bringing a stoic, serious energy, while Ramaiah brims with an eagerness to talk about everything – MG Ramachandran's endurance in politics, the history of cinema professionals in politics and his love for Kannadasan. This unlikely team is behind a film that has certainly turned heads this election season in Tamil Nadu.

Natty and Ramaiah headline the upcoming political satire, *TN 2026*, in which the TN denotes Natty's character, "Thanga Natchthiram" Kulkarni Kumar. The film revolves around Kulkarni, a North Indian who comes to Chennai for livelihood, and how he becomes an actor, a superstar, and then a political leader. Ramaiah has written the story of the film, which his son, filmmaker Umapathy S, has directed.

"I like talking about politics. Only cinema stars and politicians become subjects of ridicule among the public. Similarly, politics and cinema tend to criticise each other. As a comedy writer, I have always desired to write such political satires," says Ramaiah.

The actor-writer had long prepared this script with his son, slowly incorporating the everyday happenings on the political front. However, getting a producer was the biggest challenge, he says.

Thankfully, KRG's Kannan Ravi, who produced Ramaiah's previous film *TTT*, came to help. The team was conscious that the story had to be tailored to suit the new generation of voters. "Not everyone is embedded with the happenings of politics. However, events like members jumping ship or MLAs throwing a fit over not getting a seat have always happened. Umaphathy then imbibed the story and took it in his own direction," he adds.

Natty, meanwhile, says he was impressed by what the script was aiming to do. "Through this, we wanted teenagers, who are just starting to understand the world, to see politics for what it was," he explains, assuring that it would make you laugh as much as it makes you think.

The teaser for *TN 2026* recently stirred up controversy, as viewers speculated that Natty's character was meant to take a dig at actor-turned-politician Vijay. Natty and Ramaiah have had to clarify that the character's grey-bearded look was a coincidence and wasn't modelled on the star. "We didn't want to attack anyone or any party," clarifies Natty. "The allure of this film is much like reading one of those cinema riddles that go '3-letter hero is in a relationship with flower-named heroine' and so on. Similarly, it will be fun to think of all the politicians who suit the situations we have presented."

Natty, who started out as a cinematographer – and is known for his collaborations with Anurag Kashyap, Imtiaz Ali, Vidhu Vinod Chopra and Aanaad L Rai – is happy that he preemptively took a turn towards acting. “After cinema started adopting a corporate model, it has started to consume our days. Earlier, they used to take three months to prepare a script, three months to execute it, and three months to release it. Now, each film takes more than two years. Moreover, after completion, it might go through issues in release, like lawsuits or censorship troubles. So we need to think of alternatives, right?”

Up next, Natty has Suriya's *Karuppu* and Artharava's *Idhayam Murali* coming up. "I have also done two small films, one of which is an interesting script that tries to spread awareness about necrophilia." Ramaiah, meanwhile, will be seen soon in Vishal's *Magudam* and Chimu Devan's *Imjai Arasan 23am Pulikesi* sequel, and in a film with *Hotspot* director Vignesh Karthik.

TN 2026 releases in theatres on April 10



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